INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #23 · FRIENDS AND BELONGING

"If people really knew me, they would leave."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

If we have been rejected after being honest, shamed for a mistake, or teased for being vulnerable, we learn to hide. We show a polished version and keep the rest locked away. The result is lonely: people like the mask, and we are convinced they would reject the person behind it.

What Scripture teaches

The psalmist says, "O LORD, You have searched me and known me. You know when I sit and when I rise; You understand my thoughts from afar." God knows everything about you and has not left. Paul writes, "God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us." John says, "If we walk in the light as He is in the light, we have fellowship with one another." Being known, and still loved, is the heart of real fellowship. Not everyone is safe, but the right people can receive the real you.

> *"O LORD, You have searched me and known me"* (Psalm 139:1).

Also see

> "But if we walk in the light as He is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus His Son cleanses us from all sin" (1 John 1:7).

> "A friend loves at all times, and a brother is born for adversity" (Proverbs 17:17).

> "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us" (Romans 5:8).

> "Therefore confess your sins to each other and pray for each other so that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous man has great power to prevail" (James 5:16).

Common self-statements

- If they saw the real me, they would be disgusted.
- I have to keep my guard up.
- My past would scare them off.
- They like me only because they do not know me.
- No one could love all of me.
- I must never let anyone see my weaknesses.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming I know how others would react.
- Fortune telling: Predicting rejection.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling ashamed and concluding that I am shameful.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must reveal everything or nothing.

Challenging questions

- What am I most afraid people would discover?
- Has anyone ever known something hard about me and stayed?
- What is the cost of hiding?

- Who is a safe person I could tell a little more?
- What does it mean that God already knows me completely?
- What small, safe disclosure could I try?

Truth summary

> God knows everything about me and loves me. I do not have to be perfect to be loved. With wise, safe people, I can let myself be known little by little and discover real acceptance.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Confession
- Friendship
- Guilt/Shame
- God, All Knowing
- Loneliness

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

The God Who Stays — Matthew West
God's faithful presence challenges the expectation of rejection and abandonment.

He Knows — Jeremy Camp
Jesus understands suffering and invites people to bring their burdens to Him.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If people really knew me, they would leave"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If people really knew me, they would leave." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What do I fear they would learn?
- ☐ Has anyone stayed?
- ☐ What does hiding cost me?
- ☐ Who is safe?
- ☐ What is one small disclosure?
- ☐ What does it mean that God knows me?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God knows me completely and loves me.
- ☐ Christ died for me at my worst.
- ☐ Fellowship happens in the light.
- ☐ Safe people exist.
- ☐ I can be known gradually.
- ☐ Hiding keeps me lonely.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Psalm 139:1–3**
  "O LORD, You have searched me and known me. You know when I sit and when I rise; You understand my thoughts from afar. You search out my path and my lying down; You are aware of all my ways."
- ☐ **1 John 1:7**
  "But if we walk in the light as He is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus His Son cleanses us from all sin."
- ☐ **Romans 5:8**
  "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Known and accepted: Each week, record one small disclosure and how the person responded.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 139:1 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God knows me completely and has not left, so I can let safe people know me.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Confession" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Name the fear. Write what you are afraid they would discover.
- ☐ Choose a safe person. Pick a trustworthy friend, pastor, or counselor.
- ☐ Share a small thing. Disclose something modest and notice the response.
- ☐ Pray Psalm 139:1–3. Thank God that you are fully known and loved.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If people really knew me, they would leave": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A small disclosure
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If people really knew me, they would leave.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You know me completely and have not left. Give me courage to let safe people see more of me. Heal my fear of being rejected, and lead me to people who receive me with grace. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.